2010. Travel through the wormhole in one direction takes me backward 10 years in time; travel in the other direction takes me 10 years forward.

Neither I nor anyone else, however, can use the wormhole to travel back in time beyond 9:00 P.M., 1 January 2000. It is impossible to travel to a time earlier than when the wormhole first became a time machine.

The laws of general relativity are unequivocal. If wormholes can be held open by exotic material, then these are general relativity's predictions.

In summer 1987, a month or so after I arrived at these predictions, Richard Price telephoned Carolee. Richard—a close friend of mine and the man who sixteen years earlier had shown that a black hole radiates away all its "hair" (Chapter 7)—was worried about me. He had heard that I was working on the theory of time machines, and he feared I had gone a little crazy or senile or. . . Carolee tried to reassure him.

Richard's call shook me up a bit. Not because I doubted my own sanity; I had few doubts. However, if even my closest friends were worried, then (at least as a protection for Mike Morris and my other students, if not for myself) I would have to be careful about how we presented our research to the community of physicists and to the general public.

During the winter of 1987–88, as part of my caution, I decided to move slowly on publishing anything about time machines. Together with two students, Mike Morris and Ulvi Yurtsever, I focused on trying to understand everything I could about wormholes and time. Only after all issues were crystal clear did I want to publish.

Morris, Yurtsever, and I worked together by computer link and telephone, since I was hiding in isolation. Carolee had taken a two-year postdoctoral appointment in Madison, Wisconsin, and I had gone along as her "house husband" for the first seven months (January–July 1988). I had set up my computer and working tables in the attic of the house we rented in Madison; and I was spending most of my waking hours there in the attic, thinking, calculating, and writing—largely on other projects, but partly on wormholes and time.

For stimulus and to test my ideas against skilled "opponents," every few weeks I drove over to Milwaukee to talk with a superb group of relativity researchers led by John Friedman and Leonard Parker, and occasionally I drove down to Chicago to talk with another superb group led by Subrahmanyan Chandrasekhar, Robert Geroch, and Robert Wald.